Minutes of the
General Government Committee Meeting
2022 Operating Budget
Held Electronically at 1:00 p.m. on February 14, 2022

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Present:	Chair - Councillor	L. Bower
	Regional Councillors	M. Crawford
		S. Lee
		J. Dies
	Councillors	R. Tyler Morin
		A. Khan
	Mayor	S. Collier

1. Call to Order & Acknowledgement of Traditional Treaty Lands

Chair Bower called the meeting to order at 1:01 p.m. and acknowledged traditional treaty lands.

2. Disclosure of Pecuniary Interest

Mayor Collier declared a pecuniary interest with respect to the 'Recreation Programs / Active Living' (page 65) section of the budget, as he has a family member who works for that area of the Town.

3. Budget Chair's Opening Comments

Councillor Bower, Budget Chair, provided opening comments, thanked staff for their hard work on the preparation of the 2022 Operating Budget, and reviewed highlights of the proposed budget.

4. Finance Department Budget Presentation

Dianne Valentim, Director of Finance / Treasurer, delivered a presentation on the 2022 Operating Budget.

D. Valentim provided an overview of the Town's operating budget including process and timelines for development of the budget. D. Valentim discussed the budget framework, an overview of the budget including twelve business cases, the Library Grant, expenditures by source, revenues by source, operating budget impacts and pressures, Public Health Reserve, COVID funding, operating budget outlook, and tax calculation.

Committee Members discussed communication strategies and asked questions regarding the Municipal Property Assessment Corporation (MPAC) assessment process, projected MPAC reassessments for 2024, and the projected assessment rate per hundred thousand dollars of assessed value. D. Valentim and Shane Baker, Chief Administrative Officer, responded to questions from Committee Members.

5. Opening Public Comments & Questions

Chair Bower invited comments and questions from the public on the proposed 2022 Operating Budget.

Chris Baker, Ajax resident, expressed concerns with the Town's communication strategies for informing the public about the property tax rate impact and the 2022 estimated property tax bill, noting that the Town should improve on its communication methods and adopt a

similar approach across area municipalities. S. Baker, D. Valentim, and Mayor Collier, responded to comments from Mr. Baker.

Clive Deonarine, President, Ajax Professional Firefighters Association, expressed support for the 'Additional Fire Suppression Staff – 2022' business case.

6. Review of Budget

6.1 2022 Operating Budget

Chair Bower led the Committee through a section-by-section review of the proposed 2022 Operating Budget.

Section 2: Department Summaries and Section 3: Business Cases

Members provided questions and comments on the following sections within the proposed 2022 Operating Budget:

- **Non-Departmental (p. 26):** Committee Members asked questions regarding the allocation for contracted services, and consulting and professional services. D. Valentim reviewed COVID-19 related initiatives for 2022, noting that the projects are funded by grants, namely the Public Health Reserve and Safe Restart and COVID Recovery funding.

- **Operations & Environmental Services – Environmental Services (p.47):** Committee Members asked questions regarding increased costs associated with contracted services, impacts to the budget, and cost-reduction opportunities. D. Valentim responded to questions from Committee Members.

- **Ajax Public Library (p. 81)**: Committee Members inquired about the process for selecting the location for the Ajax Library MakerSpace. Sarah Vaisler, Chief Librarian and Executive Officer, discussed determining factors and provided rationale for the location.

Super Community Mailbox Recyclables Collection Pilot Program
(Referred from January 24, 2022 Council Meeting)

Dave Meredith, Director of Operations & Environmental Services, reviewed the Super Community Mailbox Recyclables Collection Pilot Program and associated costs. D. Meredith discussed signage options, noting that costs for signage could be absorbed within the existing operating budget.

Committee Members asked questions regarding signage costs, impacts to the tax rate, duration of a pilot program, inventory of Canada Post mailboxes in Wards 1 and 3, and who is responsible for the collection of household garbage dumped at community mailboxes. D. Meredith, D. Valentim, and Christie McLardie, Manager of Public & Strategic Affairs, responded to questions from Committee Members.

Amendment

Moved by: S. Lee

That the 2022 Operating Budget be amended by adding $20,000 to conduct a one year Super Community Mailboxes Recyclables Collection Pilot Program for the 74 identified road locations.

MOTION LOST

Recorded Vote

In Favour: Mayor Collier, Regional Councillor Lee

Opposed: Regional Councillor Crawford, Regional Councillor Dies, Councillor Khan, Councillor Tyler Morin, Councillor Bower

Committee Members asked questions regarding public engagement, signage initiatives, sign design, and sign placement. C. McLardie responded to questions from Committee Members.

Councillor Bower vacated the Chair. Councillor Tyler Morin assumed the Chair.

Motion

Moved by: M. Crawford

That staff be directed to prepare a report for the March General Government Committee meeting regarding the installation of anti-littering educational signage at the Town's Super Community Mailbox locations, including program details and costs.

Members discussed the proposed motion and timing relative to approval of the 2022 Operating Budget.

Motion to Refer

Moved by: S. Lee

That the installation of anti-littering educational signage be referred to the February 2022 Council meeting for consideration of program details and costs.

CARRIED

Councillor Bower assumed the Chair.

7. Closing Public Comments & Questions

Chair Bower invited any final comments and questions from members of the public.

Chris Baker, Ajax resident, asked questions regarding the cost of living rate increase for employees including associated budget costs, additional infrastructure costs related to growth including maintenance/repair costs for new sidewalks and repair costs for new curbs, annual costs for sidewalk maintenance and curb repair, maintenance standards and thresholds, rationale for the allocation of municipal tax for Pat Bayly Square, and Automated Speed Enforcement (ASE) program annual costs and revenue generation. D. Valentim and D. Meredith responded to questions from Mr. Baker.

Clive Deonarine, Ajax Professional Firefighters Association, thanked staff for their work on the 2022 Operating Budget.

8. FIN-2022-01: 2022 Operating Budget

Members separated the 'Recreation Programs & Active Living' (page 65) section for the purposes of voting. Mayor Collier abstained from voting on the separated section due to his declared pecuniary interest.

Moved by: S. Lee

That Council approve the 'Recreation Programs & Active Living' section of the 2022 Operating Budget (page 65).

CARRIED

Recorded Vote

In Favour: Regional Councillor Lee, Councillor Tyler Morin, Regional Councillor Crawford, Regional Councillor Dies, Councillor Khan, Councillor Bower

Opposed: None

Committee Members and Chair Bower thanked staff for their hard work in preparing the 2022 Operating Budget.

Moved by: S. Collier

1. That the 2022 Net Operating Budget in the amount of $79,463,800, including the business cases and a transfer of $778,000 from the Stabilization Reserve be approved;

2. That the Capital Ajax Library MakerSpace Business case in the amount of $524,000 be approved and that this project be funded from the 2021 Operating budget surplus retained by the Library as per the Library Reserve policy, in the amount of $250,000. In addition, a one-time transfer of $274,000 from the Library's 2021 operating surplus be utilized to help fund this capital project;

3. That the amount of $77,688,700 be set as the General levy tax for 2022.

CARRIED

Recorded Vote

In Favour: Mayor Collier, Regional Councillor Crawford, Regional Councillor Dies, Councillor Khan, Regional Councillor Lee, Councillor Tyler Morin, Councillor Bower

Opposed: None

9. Adjournment (3:11 p.m.)

Moved by: A. Khan

That the February 14, 2022 meeting of the General Government Committee Operating Budget Meeting be adjourned.

CARRIED